

KAMAL KANTA

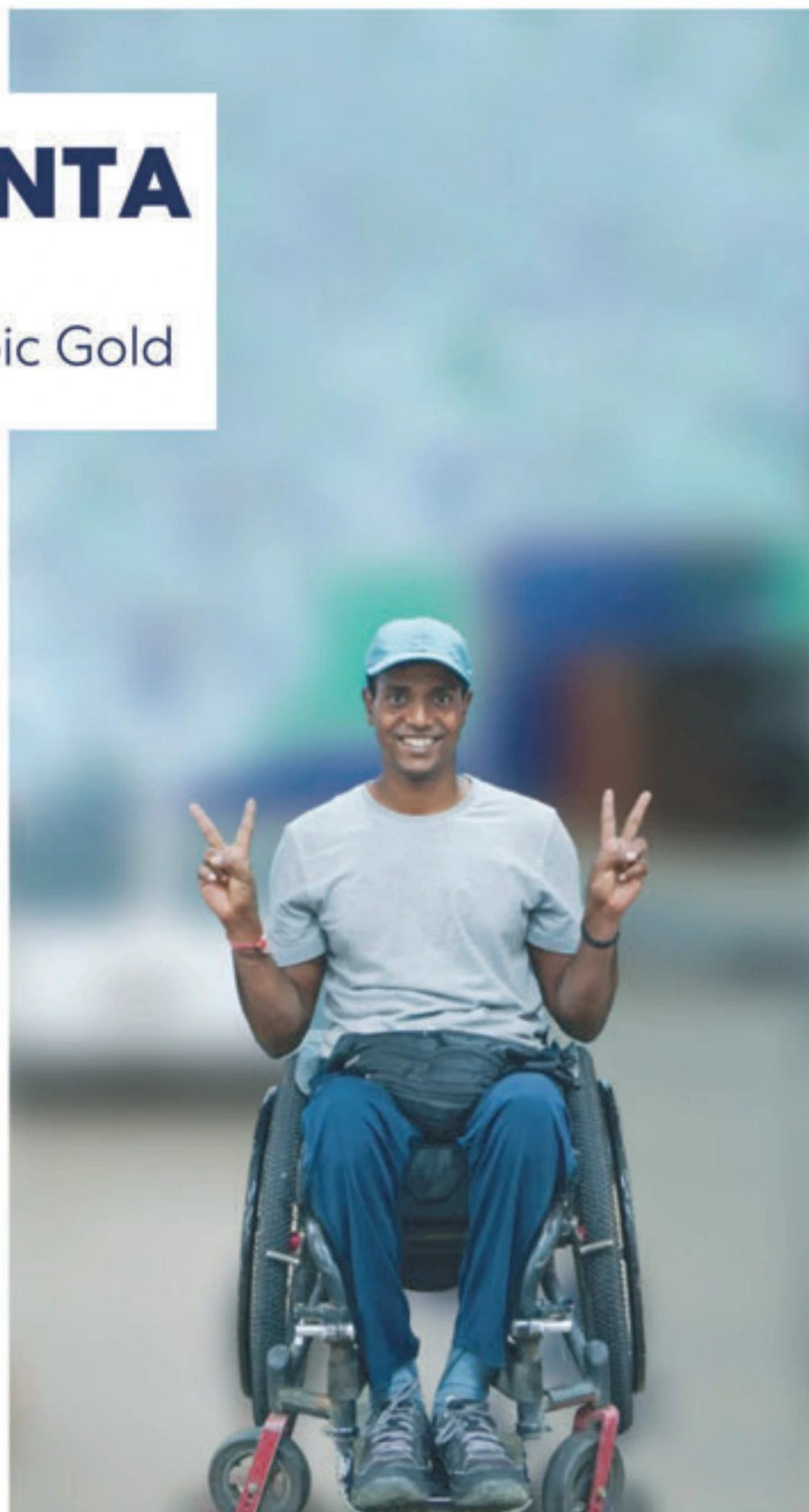
Racing Beyond Limits, Dreaming of Paralympic Gold

On a cold December evening in 2014, a volleyball game in Odisha turned tragic when 22-year-old Kamal Kanta Nayak fell and fractured his spine. Paralysed from the waist down, doctors told him he would never walk again. For a year, despair loomed—until his mother's words sparked a turnaround: "If sports became the reason for your fall, let it also become the reason for your triumph."

Born in Nijampur, Puri district, to a farmer father and homemaker mother, Kamal grew up with two sisters and a passion for sports. In 2016, persuaded by his elder sister, he reluctantly entered a wheelchair marathon in Bhubaneswar—and won. The wheelchair was no longer a cage; it became his wings.

From there, he turned survivor into mentor. As a Peer Mentor at SVNIRTAR, he has guided over 1,000 people with spinal cord injuries. Through Enable India, he helped establish wheelchair basketball, rugby, and marathon teams in Odisha, inspiring more than 25 para-athletes to compete nationally.

Then came history. India's first ultra-wheelchair marathoner, Kamal completed over 100 races and in 2022 set a Guinness World Record by covering 213 km in 24 hours on a manual wheelchair, eclipsing the previous 182 km mark. His medal tally is equally inspiring—gold medals and a national record in swimming (2023–24), two more golds and a silver at the 2024–25 Nationals, plus podiums in 5000m and javelin throw. He has also represented India at the 2025 World Para Grand Prix in Delhi and the Indian Open Para Athletics International in Bengaluru.



Global recognition followed with the Discovery Award 2023 from the UN Office in Vienna. Yet Kamal's eyes are firmly on the 2028 Paralympics. The Odisha Sports & Youth Services Department has backed his journey with cash awards and full support. Training at the ABTP Sports Science Centre, Kalinga Stadium, Kamal continues to set an inspiring example of resilience and discipline.

Kamal Kanta Nayak is not just racing for medals—he is racing against fate itself, proving that destiny can wound, but determination always heals.